Born Guilty

By Ari Roth

RUDOLF: Come, Peter. Enough questions. I want to ask one of you now. Do you ever get nightmares? You know the ones. Big? Black? Lacerating? What do you do with them? I've been to doctors, therapists, specialists: "Come to terms," they say. Yes, but whose? No terms exist, wouldn't you agree?

INTRODUCTION

"Born Guilty" is a play based on a 1988 oral history by Peter Sichrovsky, a Jewish journalist and a child of Holocaust survivors who, after growing up and playing with children of former Nazis, decided to start asking them what their daddies had done during the war and simply tape-record their answers. "Born Guilty" was published to international acclaim for its insightful portraits of deeply complex and conflicted people, whose damaged psychology, previously ignored, was both frightening and telling. What do the children of murderers look like? They look like us. We are all . . .

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RUDOLF: Always at night, they come, tear me out of bed, push me into a car, men in uniforms. We stop at a house. I'm shoved down stairs into a room. A white room. I'm handed a towel and cake of soap. They rip off my pajamas. Doors lock. I look up, I see them: Shower heads. And through the holes, a hissssssss. Fall to the floor. Soap cake turning to Zyklon. Trouble breathing. Beginning to choke. Rush for the door, try to open it, bang on it, silent scream, eyes are burning. Fingernails. Excrement. Tractor ploughs. My parents eating cheesecake. I wake up. As soon as I close my eyes it starts again – shower heads, fingernails, cheesecake.

Well? What am I? Hero? Villain? Victim? Murdered? I think I 'm a murderer, and do I get any congratulations for it, hmmmm? What about you? You think I'm a fraud, don't you? Tell me, Peter. Does the name "Project Reinhard" ring a bell? . . . I thought it might. Can you imagine, growing up in South America surrounded by *Einzadst Reinhard*!? German schools, German book store, German tavern, German butcher, all in the middle of a jungle!

All the money came from "Reinhard." Fake names. Fake passports. By the time I was ten, it has moved us four times. Then one day, they stopped looking for us, we were no longer dangerous. We were allowed to settle into a nice little villa, surrounded by nice little slaves – I can't tell you where exactly, it's too horrible, how we ruined them; Oh, those poor little brown people. Overnight, we had become victors. Eternal spring, fertile soil. Is this more what you'd like to hear?

A paradise, that's what it was. But I was fat. A real officer's kid. "Why was I born?" Hmmmm? Have you ever asked yourself? Where did our parents get the insane notion to make a child? This was the question asked by Jodl after he was sentenced to death at Nuremberg. Quite a question.

I have read everything from that trial, eight thousand pages. Of all the defendants, Hans Frank I believe is the only one to have voiced any regret. I often try to imagine what father would have said, "What's all the excitement about?" He didn't do anything. "Driving into a village? Rounding up some Poles? Walk to a clearing, men here, women there. Men dig a trench and the women pile their clothes?" Once, one single time, my father was drunk enough to talk about it, how terrible it had been, that time they had to shoot the children one by one with a hand-gun because those idiotic soldiers had aimed their rifles too high. "Oh my God!" he sobbed "What bad times those were!" How he loved to whine . . In his will he requested to be buried in Germany, but I prevented it. No more orders. He used to whip me repeatedly for even the slightest provocation. I remember once, he discovered some money missing. Not much. He used to throw change in a bowl for tips and now it was gone. Well, he decided he was going to show us who was Boss! So one night he called in The Slaves. One by one, he told them they had "one hour to report the culprit or they'd all be fired!" I was twelve at the time. Slowly, I raised my hand. I suggested that maybe dear papa might be mistaken: Perhaps it was I who had taken the money . . . ! Father turned birght red. He sent them out, all the while cursing them. "HOW DARE YOU? HOW DARE YOU?" And you know why he was so upset? Because I'd said it in SPANISH. "Dejelos solos;

Yo lo hice; Y fui el que tome eldinero!" I'd humiliated him in front of The Help! My first puny triumph.

By the time I was fifteen, I had gotten quite good at it. I'd lost twenty pounds. Suddenly I had a lot of friends. I would hitch-hike into town. I could have anyone I wanted. Back then, of course. You know what mother said? "Twenty years ago they would have pinned a pink triangle on you!" My father, he just wanted to kill me, or maybe himself first, then me. It was all over for German honor, that's for sure. No more beer in the taverns. No more chairman of the annual carnival committee. They crawled into their shells. Once I realized, I became completely uninhibited. I brought friends over, left magazines under the bed so they could find them. I dressed like a fag, talked like a fag, "especially if a visitor ever came to the door!" I really let 'em have it. You should have seen. I was kicked out of school for sexual molestation, it was beautiful! My father was called to the principal's office. I think it was the second worst day of his life! I am convinced that anything, even being charged with Crimes Against Humanity, would have been preferable. But his son A FAGGOT!?

You see, here's my theory: I think he drove into that tree on purpose. "Burned beyond recognition" That's what was written on the report. And it was gorgeous. Absolutely gorgeous. A fireball. An atomic blast. Unfortunately, I didn't see it. But I was there. The night after the funeral I went back to the cemetery and pissed on his grave, trampled on it, cried, went crazy. I was my own personal farewell. The next day, I waited for friends to call. Nothing. No cake, No congratulations. Did even on of those creeps tell me how much they admired me?

So I sold everything and came to Berlin. After all, I still had my German passport, and all the money I needed. I still don't have to work, and I don't. I don't work. I haven't done a thing in fifteen years except read about the Third Reich, and what's wrong with that, hmmmm? Who reads anymore? Just us. Over and over I come across my father's name, his old one. I don't think I can mention it here. It stays with me – a deeply buried secret.

SOURCE INFORMATION

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AWARDS

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